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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, APRIL 20, 2025 • \$6



Exploring the American frontier

PHOTOGRAPHY BY MATT MCCLAIN • STORY BY SUSAN LEVINE

The West has long captivated Americans’ imaginations with its iconic vistas and mythical lore. Yet endless transformation driven by technology, economics and wealth may be the region’s most significant feature, one that explains both its past and its future. ¶ Washington Post photographer Matt McClain traversed this evolving frontier to look for some of the most pronounced signs of change. Guided by population, employment and other data, his search ultimately landed him in five communities from Montana to New Mexico. In each, he took in the old and new. **Special Section**

White House advocates for unilateral executive powers

BY CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

Donald Trump’s second presidency has been defined by his conviction that he govern alone, with escalating disregard for the courts or Congress.

As he approaches his 100th day in office, Trump appears increasingly emboldened to push the boundaries of executive power. He and his top advisers argue he is acting with a broad mandate from U.S. voters as he drives an agenda to remake American society and the global economy, even amid many legal challenges.

But as courts challenge Trump’s drive for unilateral authority, the White House is in-

creasingly circumventing unfavorable decisions with a tone of defiance.

Administration officials have suggested last week that they are not bound to follow court orders to return Maryland resident Kilmar Abrego García, who the government has admitted was mistakenly sent to an El Salvador prison.

On Wednesday, a federal judge said he would launch proceedings to determine whether Trump administration officials should face criminal contempt

SEE **POWER** ON A10

Insurrection Act: Trump to weigh a possible new tactic for border. **A7**

Three ex-presidents unleash their criticism of current one

BY NAFTALI BENDAVID

Barack Obama urged Americans to resist President Donald Trump’s bullying. Joe Biden warned that Trump is wrecking the “sacred promise” of Social Security. Bill Clinton decried the emphasis on grievances and the need to dominate.

In an extraordinary stretch of just over two weeks, three former presidents have taken to the public stage to sound the alarm against the current occupant of the White House, despite the tradition that former presidents generally refrain from publicly

criticizing their successors.

Obama, Biden and Clinton did not explicitly name Trump, but their message was unmistakable. The three Democrats said, as much by their presence as their words, that these are unusual times for American democracy, that norms are being disregarded and extraordinary measures are required. The only living president who has not spoken out since Inauguration Day is Republican George W. Bush, though he has made little secret of his antipathy for Trump.

“Former presidents are

SEE **PRESIDENTS** ON A9

Joining together in hope and fear

Sanders and Ocasio-Cortez rallies draw Democrats yearning to connect

BY MAEVE RESTON

NAMPA, IDAHO — Making her way through the crowd at the cavernous Ford Idaho Center to see Sen. Bernie Sanders and Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez last week, 31-year-old Kelsey Gowing confessed she had at first doubted she could persuade anyone to come with her in this deep-red state.

The first few months of the Trump administration have

felt increasingly isolating to the stay-at-home mom of two. She is alarmed by the cuts to federal education programs and disturbed by the increasing boldness she sees from people who are “just outright hateful to anybody different than them.”

“It feels like every day is a new horror show,” Gowing said. She is surrounded by other moms and family members “who don’t think like I do,” she

said. “That can be really lonely.”

But now in the arena, she and 34-year-old Ariel Olvera — whom Gowing introduced as one of her “two liberal friends” — were thrilled to see people filling the seats for Sanders (I-Vermont) and Ocasio-Cortez (D-New York) in a state Donald Trump won by more than 30 percentage points. Olvera, cradling her infant in protective earmuffs, said she was ready

SEE **DEMOCRATS** ON A6



KYLE GREEN/AP

Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez and Sen. Bernie Sanders appear in Nampa, Idaho, on Monday.

High court freezes removals under wartime statute

PREDAWN ORDER LEAVES FLIGHTS IN LIMBO

Intervention doesn’t address underlying legal issues

BY ANN E. MARIMOW, MARIANNE LEVINE, JEREMY ROEBUCK AND MAEGAN VAZQUEZ

The fate of dozens of detainees in Texas remained in limbo Saturday after an extraordinary middle-of-the-night emergency action by the Supreme Court temporarily barred their removal by the Trump administration.

The court did not explain its reasoning in its unsigned emer-

gency order issued around 1 a.m. but directed the Trump administration “not to remove any member of the putative class of detainees” from the United States until further action from the Supreme Court. Two conservative justices, Clarence Thomas and Samuel A. Alito Jr., dissented.

Experts said the high court appeared to be taking an aggressive step by intervening in the high-profile issue at this stage but cau-

SEE **DEPORTATIONS** ON A6

Md. deportee’s odyssey starts at defunct registry

Case relies on 2019 gang sheet, no longer in use after claims of profiling

BY KATIE METTLER, MARÍA LUISA PAUL, JASMINE HILTON AND LATESHIA BEACHUM

The path to Kilmar Abrego García’s deportation to a notorious megaprison in El Salvador began six years ago, when a suburban Maryland police detective typed a critical allegation into a Gang Interview Field Sheet.

“An active member of MS-13

with the Westerns clique,” wrote the detective in 2019, after detaining Abrego García at a Home Depot in Prince George’s County while he stood in the parking lot looking for construction work. His proof: an unnamed confidential informant and Abrego García’s Chicago Bulls cap, which the officer wrote in his report was “indicative of the Hispanic gang culture.”

The allegations in that report — vehemently disputed by Abrego García’s family and attorneys — have become central to the government’s reasoning for deporting him in an escalating legal battle between the Trump administration and the judicial

SEE **GANG** ON A8

The Sunday Take: A clash of the rule of law and presidential power. **A2**

Apple’s CEO has steered through tariff storm for now

BY JEFF STEIN, ELIZABETH DWOSKIN AND CAT ZAKRZEWSKI

As President Donald Trump’s enormous new tariffs on China rippled through global supply chains, Apple CEO Tim Cook went to work behind the scenes.

Cook spoke to Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick about the potential impact of the tariffs on iPhone prices, two people familiar with the phone call said, speaking on the condition of anonymity to reflect private conversations that were previously unreported. Cook spoke with other senior officials in the White House, the people said. And he refrained from publicly criticizing the president or his policies on national television, as many other executives have over the past several weeks.

Within days, the Trump administration agreed to exempt from import duties electronic products that Apple produces in China, an action that also granted a reprieve to other large U.S. firms, including HP and Dell. Trump did so despite the recommendations of senior White House aide Peter Navarro, who had wanted the taxes to remain in place, the people said.

Since the exemption was an-

SEE **APPLE** ON A11

China: Trade war leaves Beijing’s neighbors walking a fine line. **A13**

THE NATION

Hundreds of rallies are held across the country against Trump’s agenda.

BOOK WORLD

The son of a legendary agent tells the story of a vanished Hollywood.



SPORTS

A 340-mile relay race with no route, no rules and one goal: Be fastest.

ARTS & STYLE

Ryan Coogler’s latest movie sings the blues. And how vampires fit in.



TRAVEL

Yes, Times Square is a tourist trap. But these restaurants are worth it.

BUSINESS

Elon Musk’s fury over a Tesla probe forewarned his war on Washington.

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The Washington Post / Year 148, No. 54192

